

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**
Contract: 4♥
Declarer: North
Lead: ♣A

Board: 2
Dealer: **South**
Contract: 4♠
Declarer: East
Lead: ♥K

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**
Contract: 4♥
Declarer: South
Lead: ♣4

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**
Contract: 4♥
Declarer: West
Lead: ♠Q

Board: 5
Dealer: **North**
Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♦2

Board 1

North Deals

None Vul

♠ Q J 10 7

♥ J 9 3

♦ A J 4

♣ 9 7 2

♠ A 5

♥ A K Q 7 6 4

♦ Q 7 3

♣ 8 5



♠ 9 3 2

♥ 8

♦ 10 9 6 5 2

♣ A K Q J

♠ K 8 6 4

♥ 10 5 2

♦ K 8

♣ 10 6 4 3

West

North

East

South

1♥

Pass

2♥

Pass

3♦

Pass

4♥

All Pass

4♥ by North

Lead: ♣A

North plays 4♥. East leads the ♣A, ♣K, ♣Q.

North plays 4♥. East leads the ♣A, ♣K, ♣Q.

Losers: ♠ 0 : ♥ 0 : ♦ 2 : ♣ 2 : Total = 4

You must eliminate one ♦ loser, that means ruffing it in dummy. You would like to pull trumps first but you cannot chance pulling two rounds because if they don't split 2-2 you would have to leave one out until after you had ruffed the ♦. The problem would then be that the defender who took the ♦ A might lead the third trump, preventing your ruff.

So first you must drive out the ♦ A. After you ruff the ♣ you play a ♦ to dummy's ♦K. West takes the ♦ A and leads a trump. You win in your hand, pull one more trump, then play ♦Q, ♦7, ruffing in dummy. Back to your hand with the ♠A, pull the last trump and claim.

As you see you couldn't afford to pull trumps until after the ♦ ruff.

And you couldn't get the ♦ ruff until after you had forced out the ♦ A.

You have a straightforward 1♥ opening bid.

Partner responds 2♥.

With 17 points and two doubletons you are on the borderline between passing and bidding game. If partner has the top of his 6-10 points you want to be in game, if he is at the bottom you don't.

A reasonable bid would be 3♥, inviting partner to bid game with a maximum.

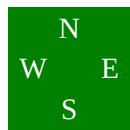
A better bid is 3♦, a Help Suit Game Try. This says the same thing, bid game with a maximum, but also says "Use your ♦ holding to help you decide."

That was just what South needed. He only had 7 points but decided the ♦ help was worth an extra point or two.

Board 2
South Deals
N-S Vul

♠ A J 4 3
♥ 4
♦ K 7 3 2
♣ A K 7 3

♠ Q 10 9
♥ 8 5
♦ 10 9 8 6
♣ 10 8 5 4



♠ K 7 6 2
♥ A 7 6 3
♦ A 5
♣ 9 6 2

♠ 8 5
♥ K Q J 10 9 2
♦ Q J 4
♣ Q J

West	North	East	South
			1 ♥
Dbl	Pass	2 ♠	Pass
4 ♠			
All Pass			
4 ♠ by East			
Lead: ♥K			

When responding to partner's Takeout Double:- with 0-8 points you bid cheaply- with 9-11 points you jump in a suit- with 12 or more points you cue-bid their suit

You have 11 so you jump to 2 ♠. Partner bids 4 ♠ and you pass.

East plays 4 ♠. South leads the ♥K.

East plays 4 ♠. South leads the ♥K.

Losers: ♠ 1 : ♥ 3? : ♦ 0 : ♣ 1 : Total = 5?

The loser count is somewhat misleading because obviously you can ruff some ♥s in dummy.

Sometimes it is better to count winners, even though it is a suit contract. Winners: ♠ 2 : ♥ 1 : ♦ 2 : ♣ 2 : Total = 7

Thinking like this makes it clear that you must win 3 of your 4 small trumps. The best way to do this is to win the ♥A and pull 2 rounds of trumps with ♠A and ♠K, spurning the finesse. Trumps split 3-2, so leave the master trump out and cash your other high card winners. Then start cross-ruffing, ♥s in dummy and ♦s in your hand. The defender with the master trump is welcome to ruff with it whenever he wants - it won't stop you from coming to 10 tricks.

You may have been tempted to play the ♠K, then finesse South for the ♠Q.

If you tried that North would have won his ♠Q, then played another ♠. That would leave both you and dummy with only one trump each and you would have come up a trick short. You can afford to pull just two rounds of trumps, then must cross-ruff with your remaining four.

Board 3

South Deals

None Vul

♠ K J 9
♥ 10 2
♦ K 7 4 3
♣ Q 10 6 4

♠ 8 6 2

♥ K 9 8 7

♦ A Q J 10

♣ 8 3



♠ A 10 5 4

♥ J 5

♦ 9 6

♣ K 9 7 5 2

♠ Q 7 3

♥ A Q 6 4 3

♦ 8 5 2

♣ A J

West	North	East	South
			1 ♥
Pass	3 ♥	Pass	4 ♥
All Pass			

4 ♥ by South

Lead: ♣4

itself, in case he has ♦ K x x x you also have to have three entries to your hand. Two of them will be the ♥A and ♥Q and the third entry must be the ♣A.

So you win the first trick with the ♣A and immediately take your first ♦ finesse. It wins, so you return to your hand with a ♥ to the ♥Q and take another ♦ finesse. Back to your hand with the ♥A (pulling the last trumps) and take a third ♦ finesse. Finally on the ♦A you can discard either your ♣ loser or a ♠. You will have to give up three tricks at the end.

This plan would work 50% of the time, whenever West was dealt the ♦K.

Any other plan that was based on West holding the ♦K would work **ALMOST** 50% of the time but would fail when West had three protectors for the ♦K.

You open 1 ♥, partner responds 3 ♥.

What is your next bid?

Partner's 3 ♥ response shows 11-12 points with good trumps.

With your 14 points you decide to bid the game.

South plays 4 ♥. West leads the ♣4, East plays the ♣K.

South plays 4 ♥. West leads the ♣4, East plays the ♣K.

Losers: ♠ 3 : ♥ 0 : ♦ 2 : ♣ 1 : Total = 6

There is no hope of extra winners except the ♦ suit. You are wide open in ♠s, so you have to hope that West holds the ♦K. But that won't be enough by

Board 4

West Deals

Both Vul

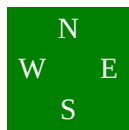
♠ A 4 2
♥ Q J 10 5 3
♦ K J 7
♣ A 3

♠ Q J 10 8

♥ 9 4

♦ A 6 3 2

♣ 10 9 6



♠ K 7 3
♥ A 8 6 2
♦ Q 4
♣ Q 7 5 4

♠ 9 6 5

♥ K 7

♦ 10 9 8 5

♣ K J 8 2

West	North	East	South
1♥	Pass	3♥	Pass
4♥			
All Pass			
4♥ by West			
Lead: ♠Q			

now? Visualize the likely defense actions if you do. Say South wins the ♥K. He will surely play another ♠, knocking out dummy's ♠K. Whenever you try to set up ♦s the defense will take their ♠ trick and you will eventually go down.

What happened is that you gave the defense a tempo and let them control the timing of the play. You should not have rushed into the ♥ finesse. Instead suppose that you win the first trick with dummy's ♠K and immediately play the ♦Q. The defense can take their ♦A when they want to and push another ♠, but now the timing is on your side. You can discard a ♠ from dummy on your good ♦ in time.

Take the ♥ finesse before you set up a ♦ trick and you will be just fine if the finesse wins. But if it loses you will lose a tempo and the defense will get to your ♠ loser before you can set up a ♦.

Set up the ♦ winner before you take the ♥ finesse and you will always be able to dump the ♠ loser no matter who has the ♥K.

You have 11 (perhaps 12) points and four trumps. Just right for a limit raise.

So you bid 3♥ and partner goes to game.

East would play 4♥.

West plays 4♥. North leads the ♠Q.

West plays 4♥. North leads the ♠Q.

Losers: ♠ 1 : ♥ 1 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 1 : Total = 4

You know you can't get rid of the ♦ loser, and it's hard to imagine a way that would let you get rid of the ♣ loser. The ♥ loser depends on the finesse. So you should try to find somewhere to put the ♠ loser.

First you win the ♠A. You know that you will eventually take the ♥ finesse, so should you take it

Board 5

North Deals

N-S Vul

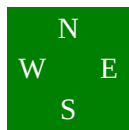
♠ 8 6 5
♥ 9 7 3
♦ Q 10 6 3
♣ A 9 2

♠ A J 9 3

♥ K 8 2

♦ A 8

♣ Q J 5 3



♠ K 7 2

♥ 10 5 4

♦ K J 9 2

♣ 7 6 4

♠ Q 10 4

♥ A Q J 6

♦ 7 5 4

♣ K 10 8

West	North	East	South
	1NT	Pass	2♣
Pass	2♠	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by North

Lead: ♦ 2

With 15 points and a balanced hand of course you open 1NT.

Partner's response is 2♣.

Partner's 2♣ bid is Stayman asking you to name a 4-card Major.

You bid 2♠, but that must not have been the Major he wanted so he bids 3NT.

North plays 3NT. East leads the ♦ 2. West plays ♦ Q. You hold up on this trick and West returns the ♦ 3.

North plays 3NT. East leads the ♦ 2. West plays ♦ Q. You hold up on this trick and West returns the ♦ 3.

Winners: ♠ 1 : ♥ 4 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 0 : Total = 6

You need to get three more winners and you have two very clear possibilities.

If West holds the ♠ K you can finesse him out of it and win an additional 3 tricks in the suit. The problem with this approach is that half the time East will hold the ♠ K and you will go down.

Or you can drive out the ♣ A and definitely set up an additional 3 tricks in that suit. The problem with this approach is that if the defender's ♦ s split 5-3 they will be able to win 4 ♦ s and the ♣ A.

If you pay attention to the opening lead this becomes a simple decision. East led the ♦ 2. Assuming that was fourth down then he must have led from a 4-card suit. So it looks like the ♦ s must be splitting 4-4 and it is safe for you to establish ♣ s. So you drive out the ♣ A. The defenders take their other 2 ♦ s but you make the game losing only 3 ♦ s and the ♣ A.

In this layout the ♠ finesse fails, as it would do half the time.

East's lead of the ♦ 2 should have made you pretty sure that he had led from a 4-card suit. If the ♦ 2 is fourth down, there cannot be a fifth down. Additionally, West's return of the ♦ 3 confirmed that conclusion. If West had started with only 3 ♦ s, (say ♦ Q 6 3) his correct return at trick 2 would have been his next highest, the ♦ 6. With 4 cards in the suit his correct return is his original fourth down.